But twenty years in the presence of the charisma, power, and talent of his father had not been conducive to fostering humility and wisdom in Murad, and little by little his supporters grew disenchanted by ‘his bad conduct in all relations of life, and court and ceremonial, and in his over-weening pride and arrogance, in which he imitated his illustrious Father, and which he carried beyond all conception, boasting of being a ripe grape when he was not yet even an unripe grape…and it became known that all that transient pomp and circumstance was caused by his ignorance rather than his knowledge’.

As for Salim, remaining at court in Lahore, Munis Faruqui has shown that he spent this decade slowly cultivating the friendships that his father could not tolerate. In addition to Mirza Hakim’s supporters, whom he had already befriended, he would continue to cultivate men from clans considered quite unacceptable by Akbar—Afghan men like Shaikh Rukn ud-din Rohilla and Pir Khan, of the Lodi dynasty; also men from the Naqshbandi order of Sufis, whom Akbar had marginalized in favour of the Chishtis. In this manner, Salim not only gradually gathered around him influential men who owed their allegiance only to the prince but in doing so undermined his father’s authority.

In other ways, however, Akbar and Salim seemed to share some common enthusiasms, notably in fostering unconventional religious practices. In 1590, learning that the Christians were celebrating the Feast of the Assumption of the Virgin Mary, Akbar decided to hold a similar celebration in Lahore. He had an elaborate throne made on which he placed the picture of the Virgin Mary gifted to him by Acquaviva. He then asked all his courtiers to show their respect to the image and kiss it but the courtiers, no doubt used to the eccentricities of the court, first demanded that Salim lead the way. This Salim did ‘at once and very willingly’, followed by all the courtiers.

The following year, Lahore saw the arrival of the second Jesuit mission at the Mughal court, Akbar having sent an invitation to the viceroy at Goa. In his letter to the viceroy Akbar wrote that he wished ‘that they may dispute with my doctors, and that I by comparing the knowledge and other qualities displayed on either side, may be able to see the superiority of the Fathers over my own learned men’.

The Jesuits left a heartfelt account of the difficulties they faced in making the arduous passage from Cambay to Lahore. The journey, they